

7/20/2026

Dear Hiring Committee,

It is without hesitation, and with genuine enthusiasm, that I recommend Maximilian Then for your consideration. In a career that has spanned senior commercial leadership across complex, global organizations, I have written a number of recommendation letters — but I want to be direct from the outset: this is among the strongest I have put my name to. I served as Maximilian's second-line manager, providing strategic oversight of his work across the EMEA region as part of a large, matrixed commercial organization responsible for some of our most strategically significant partner and customer relationships. My vantage point gave me clear visibility into not just what Maximilian achieved, but how he achieved it — and that distinction matters enormously.

What first distinguished Maximilian in my mind was his instinct — and his courage — to pursue opportunities that others had passed over or written off as too complex, too ambiguous, or too early. He has a rare ability to identify whitespace: uncovered market segments, underserved customer needs, relationships that had the potential for real commercial depth but had never been properly cultivated. Where many talented professionals wait for a clear mandate or a proven playbook before moving, Maximilian moves on conviction. He defines the path, tests it with discipline, refines it under pressure, and then — critically — hands it to others. He did not treat his discoveries as personal territory; he treated them as organizational assets. This trailblazing instinct, paired with the humility to transfer what he had built, is not common. It is the mark of someone operating well above their title.

Maximilian also demonstrated something that I find even rarer than the ability to win: the ability to systematize a win and drive it across geographies. When he secured a meaningful breakthrough — whether with a customer, a consulting partner, or a cross-functional initiative — his immediate instinct was not to celebrate and move on. It was to ask: *how do we replicate this, and how quickly?* He documented the learnings with rigor, built repeatable motions, and took it upon himself to enable colleagues across the EMEA region to benefit from what he had discovered. His orientation was always global, even when executing locally. A deal closed in one country was, in his mind, a proof

point and a template — the starting line for broader impact, not the finish line. This scaling mindset is precisely what large organizations need more of, and precisely what is so difficult to teach.

Managing and growing relationships with the Big 4 consulting firms — Deloitte, PwC, EY, and KPMG — across EMEA is, in my experience, one of the most genuinely complex commercial undertakings in our industry. These are federated, globally distributed organizations where trust is earned locally, decisions are made across multiple geographies and business units simultaneously, and relationships must be cultivated at both the strategic and operational level to generate real momentum. Maximilian navigated this landscape with a sophistication. At the same time, he operated within Microsoft's own intricate internal structures — matrixed teams, competing priorities, evolving strategies — and he did so with diplomacy, patience, and effectiveness. He never allowed organizational friction to become an excuse. He built genuine trust with senior stakeholders on both sides of the table, orchestrated across complex internal and external layers, and consistently closed outcomes that were meaningful in scale and durable in nature. That combination of external relationship depth and internal organizational fluency is exceptional.

What I want to be equally clear about — because it would be easy to underweight it — is Maximilian's impact on the people around him. His contribution was never confined to his own quota or territory. He invested generously in his peers: sharing learnings without being prompted, surfacing best practices for the broader team, and consistently creating the conditions in which collective performance could rise. His colleagues sought him out. Not because they were directed to, but because he had earned their trust and his guidance was worth seeking. Maximilian's energy and steadiness lifted the teams around him in a way that is difficult to manufacture and impossible to mandate. He understood, at a fundamental level, that in a complex sales and partnership environment, no one succeeds in isolation. His individual results were strong. His team's results, in part because of him, were stronger still.

Maximilian Then combines what I consider the rare and essential trifecta for success in a senior commercial role: genuine strategic vision, relentless and disciplined execution, and the kind of team leadership that elevates everyone around him. He is ready — in my assessment, more than ready — for a role that demands someone who can build, scale, and inspire in complex, global environments.

I recommend him without reservation and with full confidence, and I would welcome the opportunity to speak with you directly should it be helpful to your process.

Sincerely, Terrie

Terrie Depew

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